

Rotten Fencepost Foundational Guide #1

Find the Cause, Not the Symptoms

Why We Keep Fixing the Wrong Problems By Kahu Phil
Stephens

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Introduction

Have you ever repaired the same problem over and over
again?

Perhaps it was your health.

Your finances.

A relationship.

Your business.

Or maybe something deep inside yourself.

You worked hard.

You sincerely wanted things to improve.

For a little while, they did.

Then, before long, the same problem returned.

If that has happened to you, you are not alone.

In fact, I believe many of life's greatest frustrations come
from one simple mistake.

We spend our lives repairing symptoms while ignoring the cause.

That lesson did not come from a classroom.

It came from a fence.

Years ago, while working around ranches, I learned something every experienced rancher understands.

When a fence begins leaning, many people immediately tighten the wire.

They replace staples.

They pull harder.

They spend hours fixing what everyone can see.

Then, a short time later, the fence leans again.

Why?

Because the wire was never the problem.

The post was.

The fence was only showing us where the real problem existed.

That simple picture changed the way I began looking at life.

Soon I noticed rotten fenceposts everywhere.

Not just on ranches.

In people's health.

In marriages.

In businesses.

In churches.

In communities.

Even in my own life.

Again and again, I watched people work harder than ever while making very little lasting progress.

Not because they lacked intelligence.

Not because they lacked effort.

Because they were repairing what was visible instead of restoring what was foundational.

That is what this guide is about.

It is not about blame.

It is not about guilt.

It is not about finding fault.

It is about learning to ask a better question.

Instead of asking,

"How do I fix this?"

Begin asking,

"What is really causing this?"

That one question has the power to change everything.

Chapter One

Why We Chase Symptoms

Symptoms are loud.

Causes are quiet.

Symptoms demand immediate attention.

Causes often wait patiently beneath the surface.

Think about everyday life.

A warning light comes on in your vehicle.

The light is not the problem.

It is telling you there is a problem.

If you disconnect the light without fixing the engine, nothing has really changed.

Yet many of us live exactly that way.

We silence the warning while leaving the cause untouched.

The same thing happens in our personal lives.

We become tired and look for another energy drink.

We become stressed and search for another distraction.

We struggle financially and look only for another paycheck.

We argue with people without asking why the same conflict keeps returning.

We treat visible results while invisible causes continue growing stronger.

That approach keeps us busy.

It rarely makes us free.

One of the greatest changes you can make is to slow down before reacting.

Whenever a problem appears, ask yourself:

"Is this the problem... or is this the symptom pointing me toward the real problem?"

That single habit can save years of frustration.

Because once the cause is discovered...

Real healing can begin.

Chapter Two

Find the Cause

One of the greatest lessons life has taught me is that asking better questions produces better answers.

Most of us have learned to ask,

"How do I make this stop?"

"How do I fix this?"

"How do I get rid of it?"

Those questions are understandable.

They are also incomplete.

Before asking how to fix something, we should first ask,

"Why did this happen?"

That simple question changes everything.

Imagine that every morning you walked into your kitchen and found water on the floor.

The first morning you grab a towel.

The second morning you grab another towel.

By the end of the week you become very good at mopping.

But you have never looked under the sink.

You have become an expert at treating the symptom while completely ignoring the leak.

The leak quietly continues doing what leaks always do.

The towel never solves the problem.

Many of us live exactly that way.

We become experts at coping.

Experts at surviving.

Experts at adapting.

Yet we never stop long enough to discover what is actually causing the struggle.

The Rotten Fencepost Principle invites us to become investigators instead of merely repairmen.

Instead of asking only,

"What happened?"

Ask,

"What led to this?"

Then ask,

"What led to that?"

Keep asking until you can go no farther.

Eventually you will arrive at something that no longer looks like the symptom.

You will discover a habit.

A belief.

A neglected responsibility.

A broken relationship.

A poor foundation.

Or perhaps something that has quietly been ignored for years.

That is your fencepost.

That is where real work begins.

Real change almost always feels slower than temporary relief.

Replacing a rotten fencepost takes more effort than tightening a wire.

Repairing a foundation takes longer than patching a crack.

Changing daily habits requires more patience than buying another quick fix.

But only one of those produces lasting results.

The other simply delays the next repair.

The encouraging news is this:

Once the cause is corrected, many of the symptoms begin correcting themselves.

That is why this principle reaches into every part of life.

When the roots become healthy...

The fruit changes.

When the foundation becomes stronger...

Everything built upon it becomes stronger as well.

The goal is not perfection.

The goal is progress.

One fencepost at a time.

Chapter Three

Your Personal Fence Walk

Reading this guide will accomplish very little unless you are willing to take an honest walk through your own pasture.

Every rancher eventually leaves the barn.

He stops looking at maps.

He stops talking about fences.

He walks the fence.

Now it is your turn.

Choose one area of your life that has frustrated you the longest.

Do not choose five.

Choose one.

Perhaps it is your health.

Perhaps your finances.

Perhaps your relationships.

Perhaps your work.

Perhaps your spiritual life.

Now write down the symptom.

Not the explanation.

Not the excuse.

Just the symptom.

Examples might be:

"I am always tired."

"I never seem to have enough money."

"I keep arguing with the people I love."

"I start things but never finish them."

"I know what is right, but I struggle to do it."

Now ask yourself these questions slowly.

Do not rush.

What is happening?

Why is it happening?

What happened before that?

What patterns keep repeating?

What responsibility belongs to me?

What have I been avoiding?

If I were standing outside my own life, what would I notice?

These questions are not meant to make you feel guilty.

They are meant to make you aware.

Awareness is where wisdom begins.

You cannot replace a fencepost you refuse to see.

But once you see it...

You can begin replacing it.

And that is where hope begins.

Not when everything is fixed.

When the real problem is finally found.

Reflection Questions

Take your time with these questions.

There are no perfect answers.

There are only honest ones.

Write your thoughts down. You may be surprised by what you discover when you see your own words on paper.

Looking at the Fence

What problem in my life seems to return again and again?

What have I done in the past to temporarily fix it?

Did those solutions solve the problem or simply postpone it?

Looking at the Past

What might be the real cause beneath the symptom?

What habits have I accepted that may be contributing to this problem?

What truth have I been avoiding?

Looking Forward

If I addressed the cause instead of the symptom, what could my life look like one year from now?

What is one fencepost I can begin replacing today?

Personal Action Worksheet

Knowledge becomes wisdom only when it is applied.

Choose one area of your life.

Do not try to rebuild the entire ranch this week.

Choose one fencepost.

The Symptom I See

The Cause I Believe Is Beneath It

One Action I Will Take This Week

When Will I Begin?

Who Will Hold Me Accountable?

Remember:

Small, consistent actions build strong foundations.

Grand promises rarely do.

Seven-Day Action Plan

The purpose of this plan is not to change your entire life in one week.

Its purpose is to begin walking in a new direction.

Day One

Choose one recurring problem.

Write the symptom.

Do not try to solve it yet.

Simply observe it honestly.

Day Two

Ask one question throughout the day:

"What is really causing this?"

Write down every thought that comes to mind.

Do not judge your answers.

Simply collect them.

Day Three

Identify one habit that supports the symptom instead of solving the cause.

Choose one small change.

Not ten.

One.

Day Four

Talk with someone you trust.

Sometimes another set of eyes sees the leaning fence before we do.

Listen more than you speak.

Day Five

Take one practical step.

Make the phone call.

Schedule the appointment.

Offer the apology.

Create the budget.

Take the walk.

Whatever your fencepost requires...

Begin.

Day Six

Reflect on what you have learned.

Has your understanding changed?

Have you discovered something beneath the surface that you had not noticed before?

Write it down.

Day Seven

Celebrate progress.

Not perfection.

Thank God for every step forward.

Then ask yourself one final question:

"What fencepost will I replace next?"

Lasting change is built one faithful decision at a time.

Final Challenge

When you finish this guide, you will have two choices.

You can close these pages, place them on a shelf, and continue living exactly as before.

Or...

You can begin walking the fence.

No one else can make that decision for you.

No author.

No pastor.

No doctor.

No friend.

Only you.

The good news is that you do not have to repair your entire life today.

You only need to begin with the next fencepost.

Years from now, I hope you do not remember every page of this guide.

I hope you remember one simple question.

Whenever life seems to repeat the same frustration...

Whenever another symptom appears...

Whenever you feel tempted to reach for another quick fix...

Pause.

Then ask yourself:

"Am I repairing the fence...

...or am I finally replacing the post?"

If that question becomes part of the way you think...

Then this guide has accomplished its purpose.

About the Author

Kahu Phil Stephens has spent decades serving as a pastor, paniolo, musician, teacher, and lifelong student of Scripture. Through years of observing people, communities, and creation itself, he recognized a simple but profound pattern: lasting change begins by addressing causes rather than merely treating symptoms.

His passion is to help people build stronger foundations in every area of life through practical wisdom, faithful stewardship, and timeless principles.

Continue the Journey

This guide is only the beginning.

It was extracted from the Rotten Fencepost – Founder's Edition, the foundational manuscript behind an expanding library of practical resources.

If this guide has helped you begin looking beneath the surface, the journey continues in future Rotten Fencepost resources, where each guide explores another principle for building lives, families, and communities that stand the test of time.

Remember:

Find the cause.

Strengthen the foundation.

Build something that will last.

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